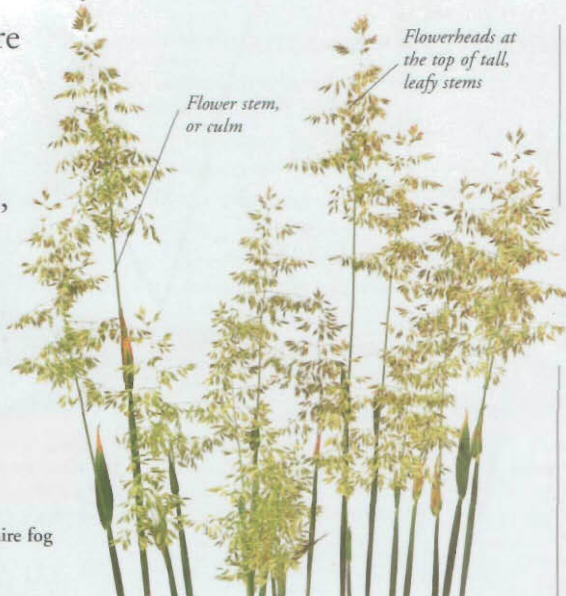


GRASSES, RUSHES, AND SEDGES



THESE THREE GROUPS of plants are all monocotyledons – flowering plants whose seedlings possess a single cotyledon, or seed leaf. In common with many other monocotyledons, grasses, rushes, and sedges have long, narrow leaves with parallel veins. They are all wind-pollinated and, therefore, do not have showy blossoms to attract animals. Instead, they have tiny flowers grouped in spikes or clusters. These produce large amounts of dry pollen.

Yorkshire fog



Cross-section of rush stem

Grasses

There are about 9,000 species of grass, including cereal crops such as wheat and barley. They are the most widespread flowering plants. Grass plants often grow close together to make a turf. Each plant has a mass of fibrous roots, leafy shoots, and flowerheads borne on long stems.



When these leaves are cut off, new shoots grow from the base of the plant.

Tillers

The reason grasses can tolerate the pressures of constant grazing or mowing is that new leafy shoots arise from buds at ground level. This kind of branching is called tillering.



Woody bamboo canes have many uses, from kitchen utensils to scaffold poles.

Soil particles are trapped and held by a network of rootlets.

Bamboo

About 830 tropical and subtropical species of grass have tough, woody stems. These are called bamboos. The tallest species reaches 35 m (115 ft) tall.

Soil binding

The roots of grass plants growing close together make a densely interwoven mat. This stabilizes loose, dry soils and prevents erosion of all kinds of soil.

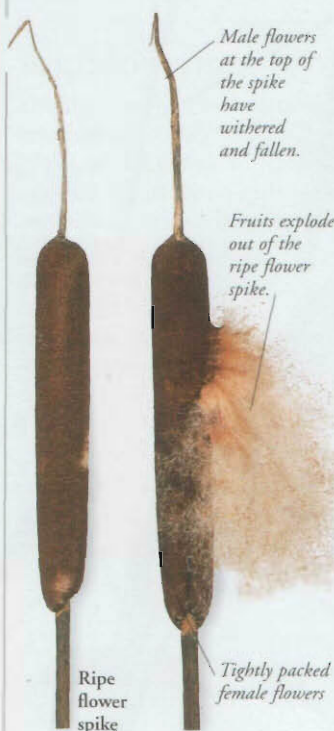


Cross-section of sedge flower stem

Sedges

The sedge family includes true sedges, cottongrasses, club-rushes, and galingales, totalling about 4,000 species.

Unlike grasses, sedges have leaves in tufts around the base of the stem. The flower stem is usually leafless and three-angled.



Ripe flower spike

Tightly packed female flowers

Reed mace

Often wrongly called bulrushes, these tall plants grow in shallow, slow-moving or still water. There are about 15 species in their own family. Each plant has a flower spike made up of densely packed flowers. This splits open when ripe, releasing a mass of single-seeded fruits.

Rushes

The 400 or so species of rush are small to medium-size plants. They are found mostly in the damper habitats of temperate and mountain regions. Rushes have green, white, or brown flowers that turn into dry fruits called capsules. Leaves may be flat like grass leaves, or cylindrical. The stems of all rushes are circular in cross-section.

FIND OUT MORE

ECOLOGY FARMING FLOWERS PLANTS PLANTS, ANATOMY PLANTS, REPRODUCTION